to be given a ‘pep talk’ by a brigadier junior to him would be laughable if it wasn’t so tragic.

With 7 Brigade no longer in the equation, a new ORBAT (order of battle) was being drawn up. The moment 1 Sikh and 4 Garhwal Rifles had fallen back on Jang, 4 Division HQ had suddenly woken up to the presence of 62 Brigade HQ which had also fallen back as a part of the general exodus from Tawang. Both these infantry battalions were taken away from 4 Artillery Brigade and placed under 62 Brigade that was, on 25 October, tasked with holding Se-la. However, unknown to the two hapless commanders of 4 Artillery Brigade and 62 Brigade, their fate had been linked to Niranjan Prasad’s unceremonious ouster. Brigadier G. S. Gill took over 4 Artillery Brigade from Brigadier Kalyan Singh. Nandi Lal, who had accompanied Harbaksh and been a part of Palit’s briefings, was shown the door and replaced by Brigadier Hoshiar Singh. The prime responsibility of 62 Brigade was to hold the new defence line at Se-la. Apart from 4 Sikh LI and 1 Sikh, Hoshiar Singh would also have 13 Dogra, 2 Sikh LI and 4 Garhwal Rifles under his command. Just why Nandi Lal was getting the axe, since at no stage had he any troops under his command, was something no one felt the need to ask.

Thapar’s new policy of having only highly decorated soldiers commanding formations in NEFA was absurd. At that point of time, Hoshiar Singh was the Colonel Administration (Col Adam) at the National Defence Academy in Khadakwasla, Poona. By Thapar’s specious reasoning, the fact that Hoshiar Singh had been awarded an Indian Order of Merit, the Indian Distinguished Service Medal and the French Croix de Guerre twenty years ago when he was a subedar in the Rajputana Rifles, now qualified him to fight the Chinese at 14,000 feet as a brigade commander. The gallant soldier was given an additional star, and with all the cadets, officers and the commandant lined up at Pashan Gate, the NDA gave Hoshiar a send-off fit for a saviour. On 29 October, Hoshiar Singh reached Se-la Top and 62 Brigade said goodbye to Nandi Lal. The last man there who had a vague idea of the terrain had been told to go home.

While the focus was mainly on the Kameng Sector and the impending battle to be fought at Se-la, Army HQ was grappling with the larger picture. In the northern extremities of Kashmir, the first Chinese attacks in the Daulat Beg Oldi, Chip Chap and Galwan valleys had more or less coincided with the assault across the Nam Ka Chu on 20 October. Here too the